

*WEST*

EDITION 2026–27

INFO BOOKLET

# For *Students*

*Real work for proven founders, for academic credit.*
*How it works, what is expected and where it leads.*

WEST VENTURES · AFFILIATED WITH AUSTIN CHRISTIAN UNIVERSITY

GOWEST.VENTURES

Cover: Emanuel Leutze, Westward the Course of Empire Takes Its Way, 1861 (study).

A LETTER

# From the managing partners

Thank you for asking about West Ventures. This booklet is written for you, the student.

Here is the arrangement. You join a small team and do real work for a founder or operator who has built something. You are expected to deliver, and you are treated as someone who can. You earn academic credit for it. Students who deliver are given more responsibility the next term: first a seat on a team, then a team to lead, then, for a few, a Fellowship working directly on the companies the studio builds.

Everything in these pages is how the studio operates today. Where a detail is still being set, it says so. If something here does not answer your question, reply to the email this booklet came in and one of us will answer it.

*Jake Oswald*

MANAGING PARTNER

*Lars Ostervold*

MANAGING PARTNER

FOR STUDENTS

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This booklet is written for students. Four companion booklets cover the program for parents, founders and executives, high schools and universities.

01 · THE STUDIO

# What West Ventures is

*A venture studio affiliated with Austin Christian University.*

West Ventures finds young people with exceptional ability, puts them to work for proven founders and operators, and builds companies with them. It does three things, and each one feeds the others.

I

## Teams

Small teams of high school and college students work on real problems for founders and operators, for academic credit. Companies pay nothing.

II

## Companies

When a project turns up an opportunity worth building, the studio builds it with the operator who found it, as a joint venture.

III

## Network

Partner high schools and universities send their best students. Founders, operators and investors bring the work.

---

**23**

Companies served by student teams so far

**78**

Students who have worked on a team

**500**

Partner schools planned by 2030

02 · THE MODEL

# Kings and *cupbearers*



GUSTAVE DORÉ, NEHEMIAH VIEWS THE RUINS OF JERUSALEM'S WALLS, 1866. NEHEMIAH WAS CUPBEARER TO THE KING.

The thesis is not tied to an industry. The studio's advantage is its model: free work, done by a large group of the country's most capable young people, for the most experienced founders and operators.

The old words for the arrangement are kings and cupbearers. Kings are proven owners and operators with more opportunities than time. Cupbearers are capable young people who need real work and someone to learn from. The studio's job is to match them, at scale.

The arrangement works because each side gets what it lacks. Founders get capable help, at no cost, on work they have no time for. Students get real work, someone to learn from and academic credit. And when a project turns up an opportunity worth building, the studio builds it with the operator who found it, as a joint venture. It expects to start about six companies a year this way.

03 · OPPORTUNITIES

# Found, *not invented*



CHARLES WILLSON PEALE, THE EXHUMATION OF THE MASTODON, 1806–08.

An 18-year-old's business ideas are usually poor. That is not a lack of intelligence; it is a lack of information. Ask someone who has built three or four companies and they already have ideas for the fourth and fifth, and they can say where the opportunity is and why.

Great business opportunities are discovered, not invented. Like a paleontologist who knows where to dig, the people who find them have spent years in an industry and can see a need before anyone has named it.

So students do not start with their own ideas. They work on problems and opportunities that proven operators have already found, and learn to see them.

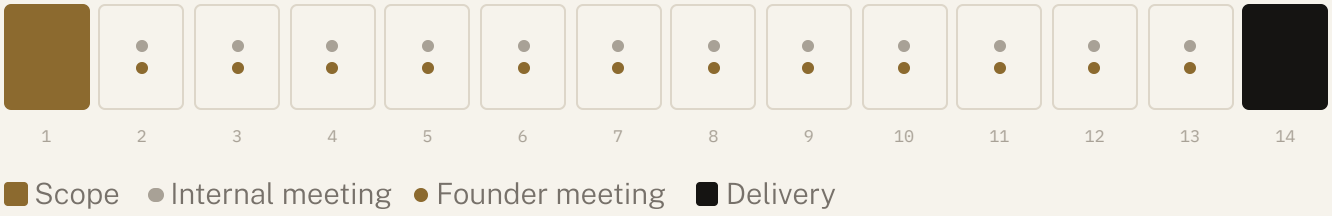
04 · HOW A PROJECT WORKS

# How a project works

*One team, one founder, one term, one written scope.*

A project is one term of work by one team, for one founder or executive. Terms run in fall, spring and summer. The founder brings a real problem and about an hour a week. The company pays nothing and keeps all equity and intellectual property. Students earn academic credit.

A FALL OR SPRING TERM




| | |
|---|---|
| *Before* | The studio matches the project with a team and a project advisor, and introduces them to the founder. |
| *Week one* | The founder and the project advisor write the scope: a week-by-week plan of what the team will deliver. |
| *Every week* | Two meetings. One internal, with the project advisor, on tasks and blockers. One with the founder, to review the work and adjust the scope. |
| *End of term* | The team delivers and hands over. The project advisor evaluates each student; the founder evaluates the project. |
| *After* | Students who delivered are invited back with more responsibility. An opportunity worth building may become a joint venture. |

05 · THE TEAM

# The team

*About five students, an experienced project advisor and the founder.*



**Two college students**, one of whom leads the team.

**Three high school Builder Scholars**, nominated by their schools.

Two roles are easy to confuse. The **team leader** is a college student who runs the team day to day. The **project advisor** is an experienced volunteer professional who coaches the team, keeps the scope honest and evaluates the work. Teams mix students from different schools on purpose, and studio staff oversee every team.

ROLES, TIME AND CREDIT

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Team leader** | College student | 5 to 10 hrs a week | 6 credit hours |
| **Contributor** | College student | 4 to 8 hrs a week | 3 credit hours |
| **Builder Scholar** | High school student | About 3 hrs a week | 3 credit hours |
| **Project advisor** | Volunteer professional | Two meetings a week | — |
| **Founder** | The company | About 1 hr a week | — |

06 · EXPECTATIONS

# What each party commits to

*The arrangement works when everyone does their part. This is what each is asked to do.*

## Students

- Give the hours the role requires, every week.
- Attend both weekly meetings, prepared.
- Deliver what the scope says, when it says.
- Keep the company's information confidential.
- Represent the company and the studio well.

## The founder

- Bring a real problem or opportunity that matters to the business.
- Write the scope with the project advisor in week one.
- Meet the team once a week and answer questions in between.
- Give honest feedback, including when the work falls short.
- Evaluate the project at the end of the term.

## The project advisor

- Run the weekly internal meeting and coach the team.
- Keep the scope current and the founder informed.
- Hold students to the standard the founder expects.
- Evaluate each student's work at the end of the term.

## The studio

- Recruit and screen students and project advisors.
- Match each project with a team that can deliver it.
- Handle all academic paperwork and credit.
- Oversee every team and step in when a project is off track.

07 · THE WORK

# The work

*Every project falls into one or more of five kinds of work.*

| | |
|---|---|
| *I* | **Market research.** Customer interviews, market sizing and problem validation. |
| *II* | **Agentic engineering.** Websites, apps, internal tools and AI agents. |
| *III* | **Branding.** Names, logos, visual identity and messaging. |
| *IV* | **Marketing.** Photo, video, copywriting and paid advertising. |
| *V* | **Sales.** Lead lists, outreach and customer pipeline. |



LIFETIME FITNESS · HEALTH & FITNESS CLUBS




OVERFLOW · GENEROSITY PLATFORM



BURLEBO · OUTDOOR APPAREL BRAND

08 · OUTCOMES FOR STUDENTS

# Outcomes for students

*Responsibility is earned one term at a time.*

| | |
|---|---|
| *01* | **Builder Scholar.** A high school student on a team, nominated by their school. Earns college credit. |
| *02* | **Contributor.** A college student on a team, doing a defined part of the scope. |
| *03* | **Team leader.** Invited after a strong term. Leads the team day to day and answers to the founder. |
| *04* | **Fellow.** The studio's most trusted students. Fellows work directly with proven operators on the studio's own companies, two or three at a time. |

**78**

Students who have worked on a team

**21**

Student Fellows named

**2×**

Gloo AI Hackathon won by ACU student teams, 2025 and 2026

Every student keeps a record of the work: a public profile listing each company they worked for, their role and what the team delivered, alongside academic credit on a transcript and a reference from a project advisor who saw the work.

09 · STUDENT STORIES

# Student stories

*Students don't need a business idea or a network. They need to show up and do excellent work.*

Most 18-year-olds have poor business ideas and no network. The studio has both: opportunities found by experienced operators, and the founders, executives and investors behind them. A student raises their hand, is placed on a real project, and is judged on effort, attitude and the work itself. When they deliver, their network grows and opportunities follow. Here are eight of them.



**Yakira Cardoso** · *p. 13*
TEAM LEADER · COLLEGE STUDENT

CE

**Cole Elzerman** · *p. 14*
TEAM LEADER · COLLEGE STUDENT

PG

**Preslee Gordon** · *p. 15*
TEAM LEADER · UPPERCLASSMAN IN COLLEGE

CD

**Connor Dore** · *p. 16*
BUILDER SCHOLAR · SENIOR IN HIGH SCHOOL

JE

**Jonah Elliot** · *p. 17*
FRESHMAN IN COLLEGE

BP

**Braden Peays** · *p. 18*
FRESHMAN IN COLLEGE

LC

**Lillia Caldroney** · *p. 19*
BUILDER SCHOLAR · HIGH SCHOOL STUDENT

MW

**Merci Wymore** · *p. 20*
BUILDER SCHOLAR · HIGH SCHOOL STUDENT

STUDENT STORY · 01

# Yakira Cardoso

TEAM LEADER · COLLEGE STUDENT

TO CONFIRM · YEAR IN COLLEGE



*An all-night pitch deck, a first-place finish and a seat on a founding team.*

| | |
|---|---|
| Project | Adoption Is An Option |
| Role | Team leader |
| Competition | First place, $12,000 |
| Now | Founding team, Adoption Is An Option |

Yakira joined the student team working with John Knox, a founder and philanthropist who was launching a nonprofit, Adoption Is An Option. When the students were given a chance to meet him, she stayed up all night building a pitch deck so she could bring him her own thinking about the organization he was starting.

He was impressed enough by the students, and by Yakira in particular, that he created a series of opportunities for them. One was a TikTok ad competition he funded, with $25,000 in cash prizes and ads judged only on how they performed. Yakira took first place and $12,000.

He then asked her to join the founding team launching Adoption Is An Option.

STUDENT STORY · 02

# Cole Elzerman

TEAM LEADER · COLLEGE STUDENT

TO CONFIRM · HEADSHOT

TO CONFIRM · YEAR IN COLLEGE

CE

*From waiting tables to leading a company spinning out of Life Time.*

| | |
|---|---|
| Gloo AI Hackathon | First place, 2025 and 2026 |
| Current project | Life Time |
| Result | About $1.2 million a year saved |
| Next | Helping lead the spinout |

Two summers ago, Cole was waiting tables. Since joining the studio he has won the Gloo AI Hackathon in Boulder, Colorado, two years in a row, and has worked on and led a series of projects for founders and executives.

One of the projects he leads now is for Life Time. His team built technology that is saving the company about $1.2 million a year in overhead. It is being spun out as its own company to commercialize, and Cole will help lead it.

STUDENT STORY · 03

# Preslee Gordon

TEAM LEADER · UPPERCLASSMAN IN COLLEGE

TO CONFIRM · HEADSHOT

TO CONFIRM · YEAR IN COLLEGE

PG

*Leading two teams, and hired by the founders of one of the organizations she serves.*

| | |
|---|---|
| Projects | Commissioned, Best Buddies |
| Role | Team leader on both |
| Now | Part-time role with Commissioned's co-founders |

Preslee has moved up through several projects and this fall leads two teams: one for Best Buddies, and one for Commissioned, a network of hundreds of Christian women entrepreneurs who gather each year to learn from one another.

Her Commissioned team helped put on this year's gathering. Working alongside the network's co-founders, she led the team well enough that they hired her as a paid, part-time member of their staff.

The event also introduced her to a great many women founders. She is learning to lead a team and deliver real value, and her network has grown faster than it could have any other way.

STUDENT STORY · 04

# Connor Dore

BUILDER SCHOLAR · SENIOR IN HIGH SCHOOL

TO CONFIRM · HEADSHOT

CD

*A high school senior with a paid role and a growing network.*

| | |
|---|---|
| Projects | launch.kids, The Care App |
| Focus | AI |
| Gloo AI Hackathon | Award and cash prize, 2026 |
| Now | Paid role at The Care App |

Connor is a senior in high school and a Builder Scholar. He contributes to two projects, launch.kids and The Care App, and his focus is AI. His skills have grown quickly from one project to the next.

At the 2026 Gloo AI Hackathon he competed on the Unify team, which won an award and a cash prize.

His work on The Care App led the company to offer him a paid role alongside school. Through it he was introduced to the creative director of Porsche, an advisor to the company, to work with him on using AI to build out the platform.

STUDENT STORY · 05

# Jonah Elliot

FRESHMAN IN COLLEGE

TO CONFIRM · HEADSHOT

JE

*A college freshman working as a fractional CTO.*

| | |
|---|---|
| Year | College freshman |
| Largest offer | $250,000 a year |
| Now | Fractional CTO for several companies |
| Rate | $150 an hour or more |

Jonah is a freshman in college. Through relationships made in the studio, he has had several offers to work for companies. One was for $250,000 a year.

He now works as a fractional CTO for a few companies, alongside school, and each pays him $150 an hour or more. He keeps building his skills and his network on studio projects.

STUDENT STORY · 06

# Braden Peays

FRESHMAN IN COLLEGE

TO CONFIRM · HEADSHOT

TO CONFIRM · SALE AND TERMS

BP

*A track win as a freshman, and a company sold within six months.*

| | |
|---|---|
| Company | Unify |
| Gloo AI Hackathon | Best in agentic engineering, 2026 |
| Outcome | Acquired · terms to come |

Braden came into the studio as a freshman. At the 2026 Gloo AI Hackathon he won best in agentic engineering for Unify, the company he is building with the studio: one platform for nonprofits in place of a stack of separate tools.

He was approached about an acquisition and sold the company less than six months later.

STUDENT STORY · 07

# Lillia Caldroney

BUILDER SCHOLAR · HIGH SCHOOL STUDENT

TO CONFIRM · HEADSHOT

TO CONFIRM · GRADE

TO CONFIRM · WHAT SHE HAS LEARNED AND BUILT

LC

*A high school student's first term, working for a bank.*

| | |
|---|---|
| Project | Regent Bank |
| Role | Builder Scholar |
| First term | Fall 2026 |

Lillia is a high school Builder Scholar. Her first project, this fall, is for Regent Bank, on a team led by a college student and coached by an experienced project advisor.

Working for a bank has meant learning how a regulated business makes decisions, meeting with the bank's team every week, and learning the research, writing and AI tools the team uses to do the work. It has also put her in the same room as the people who run a bank, at an age when few students meet anyone like them.

STUDENT STORY · 08

# Merci Wymore

BUILDER SCHOLAR · HIGH SCHOOL STUDENT

TO CONFIRM · HEADSHOT

TO CONFIRM · GRADE

TO CONFIRM · HER STORY SO FAR

MW

*One term in, on a team building a care app.*

| | |
|---|---|
| Project | The Care App |
| Role | Builder Scholar |
| First term | Fall 2026 |

Merci is a high school Builder Scholar. She began her first project this fall with The Care App, on a team of college students and other Builder Scholars.

Like every new student, she started with a defined part of the scope, meets with the company each week, and is evaluated on what she delivers. Students who do that well are invited back with more responsibility.

10 · FROM FOUNDERS

# From founders

"Cole has been outstanding on our startup — smart, technically capable, coachable, hardworking, and a true team player. His contribution reflects not only strong technical skill, but the character, humility, and mission-minded leadership ACU is developing in its students."

Paul Kent Graeve
Founder & CEO, Today Matters

"I've spent years working in Big Tech in Silicon Valley with the world's most premiere talent. The profile of the ACU student is unique. The world has a lot of knowledge, but it needs more wisdom. ACU students are showcasing a rigorously intellectual foundation coupled with a moral, Christian fabric — a combo the world desperately needs more of. I wouldn't hesitate to bring an ACU student on."

John Kronlokken
Founder & CEO, Evergreen / Ex-Corporate Strategy, Google

"As an entrepreneur, I wish I had the college experience that ACU is creating. ACU provides students the opportunities they need to become excellent, and the students are delivering on that opportunity. Coming into the engagement, I thought it would be predominantly mentorship. I was wrong. The students delivered tangible value to our organization the whole way through. Movements like this will inspire the next generation of leaders to believe God is in all things, including our work."

Anthony Ruffner
Founder & CEO, Turn

11 · FROM FAMILIES AND TEACHERS

# From families and teachers

PARENT TO BE COLLECTED

"A line from the parent of a Builder Scholar: what changed in their son or daughter over a term."

**Name**
Parent of a Fall 2026 Builder Scholar

TEACHER TO BE COLLECTED

"A line from a teacher or counselor who nominated students: why they nominated them and what came back."

**Name**
Teacher, partner high school

STUDENT TO BE COLLECTED

"A line from a Builder Scholar about the work they did and who they did it for."

**Name**
Builder Scholar, Fall 2026

STUDENT TO BE COLLECTED

"A line from a college team leader about leading a team for a founder."

**Name**
Team leader, Fall 2026

Families and teachers who would speak with a prospective family directly can be introduced on request.

12 · PRICING

# Pricing

## $5,000

*per student, per term.*

The same price for high school and college students, who work on the same teams. Companies, partner schools and universities pay nothing.

| | |
|---|---|
| **Terms** | Fall, spring and summer. Each is priced and enrolled separately. |
| **A full year** | $15,000 for all three terms. |
| **Credit** | 3 credit hours a term for contributors and Builder Scholars, 6 for team leaders. Awarded through Austin Christian University. |
| **Included** | Team placement, a project advisor, and academic credit and its paperwork. |
| **Scholarships** | Need-based scholarships are available. Price should not keep a capable student out. |
| **Effective** | Summer 2027 and later. Earlier terms are priced under the current program. |

ONE TERM

**$5,000**

3 credit hours (6 as team leader)

FALL AND SPRING

**$10,000**

6 credit hours (12 as team leader)

FULL YEAR

**$15,000**

9 credit hours (18 as team leader)

13 · STUDY ABROAD

# A term *abroad*

*Through Living and Learning International, students can live overseas for a term and stay on a team.*

Living and Learning International is a faith-based study abroad provider that works with more than forty Christian colleges and universities. Students live in residential communities with resident staff, take courses whose credit transfers home, and live in the culture. West Ventures students can spend a term in one of its locations and keep working with their team remotely, building companies from wherever they are.

| | |
|---|---|
| Quito *Ecuador* | 0.18° S · 78.47° W |
| Rome *Italy* | 41.90° N · 12.50° E |
| London *England* | 51.51° N · 0.13° W |

TO CONFIRM Locations, dates and costs are set by Living and Learning and confirmed with each student before a term abroad. Living and Learning's program fees are separate from West Ventures tuition.

14 · QUESTIONS

# Questions

### Do I need experience?

No. You need to show that you can learn quickly and do what you say you will do. Teams include students with no prior experience alongside students with a lot.

### Can I bring my own idea?

Not usually. Students work on opportunities that experienced operators have already found. Students who want to build their own company learn more, faster, by first working for someone who has done it.

### What kind of work will I do?

One of five kinds: market research, software and AI engineering, branding, marketing, or sales. The scope is written in the first week of the term.

### How is my work graded?

On the work itself. There are no tests. Your project advisor evaluates what you delivered against the scope.

### Can I do this from anywhere?

Yes. Teams work remotely. With Living and Learning International you can spend a term abroad and stay on a team.

### What happens after a good term?

Students who deliver are invited back with more responsibility: contributor, then team leader, then Fellow.

15 · NEXT STEPS

# Next steps

*1*

## Apply

College students apply directly. High school students are nominated by their school or apply directly. Reply to the email this booklet came in to start.

*2*

## Interview

A short conversation with the studio about what you have done and what you want to learn.

*3*

## Join a team

Accepted students are placed on a team before the term begins and meet their founder in week one.

CONTACT

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VENTURES

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